

AGENT OF FEMINISM Tabu's character in *Khufiya* leads the operation while carrying the weight of being an absentee parent and losing a beloved

It's not how Vishal Bhardwaj envisioned it, but it is what it is. The filmmaker has had two back-to-back releases on streaming—a series, *Charlie Chopra* (SonyLIV), followed by a feature, *Khufiya* (Netflix)—which both emerged from the constraints he found himself in. Adapted from Amar Bhushan's espionage novel *Escape to Nowhere*, *Khufiya* was meant to be a theatrical venture, but he was unable to find "male actors" who understood his vision. Bhardwaj made the lead a female and turned to the actor who trusts him blindly—Tabu. "But with female stars, you don't get enough money to make what was a huge production," says Bhardwaj. Enter the knight in shining armour in Netflix.

Meanwhile, *Charlie Chopra*, based on Agatha Christie's *The Sittaford Mystery*, was written as a feature, but once again confronted with a fund crunch and needing a star to spearhead the project, Bhardwaj turned to an OTT service only to be told they wanted a series. "There was the risk of losing the option to the book. In record time, I turned it around," he says. "These platforms are a great boon because you can tell the stories you want to."

With both adaptations and his acclaimed Shakespeare trilogy—*Maqbool*, *Omkara* and *Haider*—one would presume that Bhardwaj is a voracious reader, but he confesses he isn't. Instead, he calls himself a "selective reader", and that too one who finds the romance attached to reading physical books overrated. Yes, Bhardwaj loves the Kindle. Just don't tell his good friend, Gulzar. "It is tedious to read [a physical book]. I like to educate myself when I am reading and with the Kindle, it is quick to find the meaning of a word," he says. "I am always in favour of technology; you cannot fight it in the name of holding on to nostalgia."

Khufiya nearly escaped his radar; that is, until his friend, the late actor Irrfan, walked into the office one day and scolded him for ignoring a good read, a fictionalised take of a real account of a mole in the R&AW. Bhardwaj gave Bhushan's book another go and was impressed with the details he had captured, which included the agency using a Mother Dairy milk booth as a control room to spy on one of its own, in itself a rarity in the organisation. There was also the almost vicarious pleasure of secretly watching someone as captured in the German film *The Lives of Others*. But in Bhardwaj's hands, a feminine spirit crept into the script and the character of the mole's wife (Wamiqa Gabbi) became a pivotal character. A lesbian arc was also introduced.

Khufiya's strength lies in the character of Tabu's agent who leads the operation while carrying the weight of being an absentee parent and losing a beloved. Bhardwaj challenges the Bollywood cinematic tradition of putting mothers on a pedestal with three different shades of mothers. "We tend to see women from the gaze of a sister, a wife or a mother," he says. "We don't see they are human beings. We are all flawed and grey." Bhardwaj calls it his most "feminist film to date", despite having a film like *Saat Khoon Maaf* to his credit.

BHARDWAJ SAYS HIS NEXT PROJECT WILL PROBABLY HAVE TO BE A 'MACHO FILM'